

(I'm)Paz Total: Quantitative Evaluation of the Política de Paz Total in Colombia

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Abstract

This thesis examines whether the implementation of Colombia's Política de Paz Total (PPT) is associated with changes in monthly violent trends in three territorial cases: Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco. The analysis uses a panel dataset constructed from Colombian National Police records and ACLED event data, aggregating monthly observations of homicides, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting, political violence, and demonstrations into a single measure of violent exposure. The results indicate that the onset of peace talks is systematically linked to an increase in monthly violence, with political violence emerging as the clearest disaggregated component of this rise, and active armed-group disputes operating as the dominant non-treatment driver.

As the 2022-2026 administration of President Gustavo Petro approaches its end, the outcomes of Colombia's Política de Paz Total have become a matter of growing political and academic interest. One of the central promises of the Petro government was to reduce armed violence across the country by opening simultaneous peace talks and local negotiation processes with insurgent and criminal organizations. These processes sought to reduce confrontation, promote ceasefires, and create conditions for broader demobilization or negotiated settlement. Yet public debate and much of the existing qualitative assessment suggest that the policy has produced mixed and often disappointing results.

This thesis contributes to that debate by providing a quantitative analysis of subnational variation in violence during the implementation of Paz Total. It examines whether the onset of peace talks is associated with changes in monthly violent trends in three territorial cases: Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco.

The analysis uses a panel dataset constructed from Colombian National Police records and ACLED event data, aggregating monthly observations of homicides, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting, political violence, and demonstrations into a single measure of violent exposure. Methodologically, the thesis employs two-way fixed-effects models to estimate whether violence changes while peace talks are active, controlling for time-invariant territorial differences and common monthly shocks.

Keywords: Política de Paz Total, Colombia, Peace Process, Peacebuilding

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1 Introduction

Colombia has been on an almost continuous internal conflict since it became a republic. Yet, the last 70 years have been probably the most marked by internal conflict with a prolonged rebel war that evolved from an ideological revolution to a cartel war. The appearance of cartels and drugs in the 80s shifted the logic of the conflict into a series of conflicts of drug production and economic domination between Organized Armed Groups (AGs). This kept evolving, allowing the appearance of a vast range of different AGs, from communist guerrillas to urban gangs that want to participate in the drug economy.

On 2016 former president Juan Manuel Santos signed a peace treaty in Havannah between the largest AG in the country, the Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC), marking a milestone in the recent history of violence. The initial intention was to stop the conflict against the FARC, and initiate an special law for the reintegration of former combatants into civil life. However, due to failures in the policy implementation some of the disbanded FARC members dropped their intentions of returning into civil life and created the so-called FARC dissidents which include Estado Mayor Central (EMC) and Segunda Marquetalia (SM), effectively taking back the void positions that were left from FARC during the peace agreement, and fighting back other AGs that had begun incursions into the territories such as Ejercito de Liberación Nacional (ELN). The complexity of the conflict is such that six years after the 2016 agreement, the International Committee of the Red Cross still recognized six non-international armed conflicts in Colombia, including confrontations between the state and irregular actors as well as conflicts among illegal armed organizations themselves (Grasa, 2022, p. 4, author’s translation).

With this light context in mind, it can be argued that violence in Colombia is geographically uneven, organizationally fragmented, and historically persistent. The current cycle of violence is marked by fragmentation, sub-nationalization, and the increasing importance of localized interactions among armed actors rather than a single national logic of war (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, pp. 141-145). It resists simple dichotomies: it is simultaneously local and global, and cannot be reduced to rigid categories such as political versus criminal violence (Gutiérrez Sanín and Sánchez Gómez, 2006, pp. 8-10). The 2016 agreement did allow “multiple regions of the country to experience peace after decades of absence” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 7, author’s translation), but the conflicts

initiated by the void left by FARC eventually lead to increased violence. This is consistent with Pécaut's long-run reading of the Colombian conflict, which emphasizes the exceptional continuity of armed organization and notes that the FARC maintained both "longevity" and "cohesion" even as Colombia underwent profound social and political transformations (Pécaut, 2008, pp. 23-24).

Petro's government (2022-2026) inherited a country marked by rising humanitarian impacts, including the highest recent levels of forced displacement and confinement, continued killings of social leaders, and an increase in homicide after a long period of decline at the national level (FIP, 2023, p. 5, author's translation). Aiming to solve the violence in one go, the government designed and implemented the *Política de Paz Total* (PPT) or in English Total Peace Policy. The policy sought to negotiate simultaneously with a broad range of actors, including insurgent organizations and criminal groups, under an ambitious and territorially expansive peace agenda: the policy initiated 13 peace talks or simply called *Mesas* (tables) e.g. *Mesas Regionales* (Regional Tables) or group specific tables such as *Mesa con el ELN* (Table with the ELN). This meant, the policy aimed to negotiate with any type of armed group, including urban gangs and guerrillas, regardless of the context specific nuances.

The ambition of *Política de Paz Total* (PPT) is precisely what makes it both politically important and analytically difficult: it seeks to transform criminal activities across territories where armed governance takes very different forms. Henceforth, Paz Total requires "an integral and multi-actor approach," one that combines the reduction of direct violence through negotiated agreements with broader peacebuilding efforts aimed at structural causes of violence (Grasa, 2022, p. 1, author's translation). This complexity, might be what has brought so many difficulties to its implementation.

When analyzing the overall results of the policy, qualitative assessments tend to conclude that the policy has, opposite to its intentions, increased violence across territories and helped the AGs reconfigure and expand their operations (Swissinfo, 2026; Leon, 2026; FIP, 2026). However, there is no quantitative research on this matter, and hence no evidence that can back up the empirical findings of qualitative assessments.

Following the work from SOC-ACE (Jhonson, et. al 2026), and considering that peace talks may alter violent trends because negotiations change the strategic environment in which armed groups operate, this thesis aims to quantitatively test these claims by posing the following question: Within Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco what is the association between the timing of Petro's

Total Peace policy (2022-2026) negotiations and the monthly incidence of conflict-related events (homicide, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting, and political violence)?

Having these three examples helps understand the policy mechanism in a more generalized scope, while keeping case specific traceable nuances that are added into the main model specification. Buenaventura, Colombia's main Pacific port, is an urban setting marked by criminal governance, extortion, and territorial rivalry between Los Shottas and Los Esparteros. Arauca, an eastern border department, has a long history of insurgent organization, particularly through the ELN's Frente Domingo Laín, and is shaped by broader regional dynamics linked to the Venezuelan border, oil rents, and inter-group confrontation. Whereas Tumaco, located on the southwestern Pacific coast in Nariño, is embedded in coca-growing corridors, riverine routes, and fragmented armed orders associated with FARC dissident structures and the Segunda Marquetalia. Qualitative results provide a base and a mechanism that helps understand changes in data. For example, the fall of homicides in Buenaventura after the ceasefire of Los Shottas and Los Esparteros is explained in the article, while it is also pointed out that the violent mechanism has shifted from homicides and shootings to forced disappearance. Thus, the scope of the thesis is deliberately limited. It does not evaluate the entire national policy, nor does it attempt to explain every armed process opened under Paz Total. But it reveals a more complex mechanisms that are contributing to the impacts of the policy.

Methodologically, the thesis measures the impact of the policy by using a monthly panel constructed from Colombian National Police and ACLED data. The outcome is an aggregate monthly count of violent observations, combining homicides, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting and political violence and into a single indicator of local exposure to coercion. This design allows the analysis to capture changes in the broader observable repertoire of violence rather than focus exclusively on one category such as homicide, and to provide another insight on the overall impact of the policy.

The main model specification is a Two Way Fixed Effects (TWFE) that checks changes with territorial-case and month fixed effects. Allowing a more heterogeneous perspective, obtaining coefficients that explain a broad range of armed governance and war related violence during treatment periods. The model makes each case compare against itself over time while absorbing shocks common to all cases in a given month. The estimate of the effects of Paz Total will help assess whether

peace talks are associated with shifts in violence in three theoretically contrasting territories.

Furthermore, there are data limitations to this research. First, the analysis cannot capture all forms of coercion equally well due to data constraints. Practices such as forced disappearance, forced recruitment, massacres, and many forms of displacement fall out of scope. This matters because these practices remain central to the contemporary Colombian war. Valencia and Serrano explicitly identify “child recruitment, confinements, and extortion” as part of the less visible effects of current violence (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, p. 143). Hence, this will only achieve a limited comprehension of the violent outcomes in the conflict that follow institutional reporting.

Second, the study relies on only three territorial units, which limits partially inferential power and requires cautious interpretation of fixed-effects estimates. Third, because Paz Total remains an ongoing and unfinished policy process, the findings should be understood as an assessment of changes during implementation rather than as a final evaluation of negotiated peace outcomes. The thesis therefore measures important observable dimensions of violence, but it does not claim to capture the full range of coercive practices through which armed actors govern territories and populations.

The remainder of the thesis proceeds with seven chapters as follows. Chapter 2 will argue that violence should be understood as an instrument of territorial control and governance and that the effects of peace talks depend on timing, sequencing, and local armed order, and review literature that showcases qualitative results of PPT. The 3 chapter will provide 3.1, 3.2 and empirical strategy, explaining the panel structure, treatment coding, and the logic of the two-way fixed-effects models, followed by the 3.3. Chapter 4 will contain the exploratory results of violence across the country, region and selected cases and primary statistical results, with descriptive statistics that shows how Buenaventura and Tumaco experience declines in average violence during treatment months whereas Arauca shows an increase, although that is misleading when accounting for the fixed effects. The following section, 5 will provide the results for each of the implemented models with a description of limitations, accepting the thesis hypothesis and quantitatively supporting qualitative assessments. 6 will come back to the theoretical implications of the results, and finally 7 will outline the implications of these results and propose steps for future research.

2 Theoretical Framework

This thesis understands violence not simply as an episodic outcome of armed conflict, but as a mechanism through which armed groups govern territory, discipline populations, and manage competition. Johnson et al. (2025) state that “violence is the central factor for understanding how armed actors control and govern territories and local societies” (p. 23, author’s translation). We can understand violence from a broad set of categories. Pierre Bourdieu (1994) defines three types of violence: symbolic violence, objective violence and subjective violence. The first, is based on oppression and dominance. Applied through symbols, discourses, policies and cultural values that have an effect on subordination. Nonetheless, Žižek (2010), although agrees with this differentiation proposes a binary classification where symbolic violence is part of subjective violence.

Under this framework, Žižek (2010) explains objective violence as the violence that is directly manifested on our daily life: attacks, homicides or forced displacement. Whereas symbolic violence is that expressed through language, inequality and societal configuration. Under these terms, this thesis studies the output of violence as count of objective violence events in a month.

It includes coercive practices aimed at enforcing rules, punishing disobedience, and shaping local order, homicides, political violence, civilian targeting, terrorism and extortion. This logic is consistent with Arjona’s argument that “when armed groups control a territory and pursue long-term goals, they prefer to create rebelocracies. If they encounter a community that is likely to resist collectively, however, they are likely to limit their rule, establishing aliocracy instead” (Arjona, 2016, pp. 100-101). It is also consistent with Masullo’s claim that civilian agency “can affect the level of violence that armed groups inflict on civilians... , the distribution of territorial control and the establishment of rebel governance” (Masullo, 2020, pp. 2-3). For this reason, homicide, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting, and political violence are observable expressions of how armed actors compete, regulate, and govern.

The argument of this thesis is that peace talks may alter violent trends because negotiations change the strategic environment in which armed groups operate. Johnson et al. (2025) emphasize that “timing and sequencing are key factors in the development of dialogue processes” (p. 6, author’s translation). More specifically, they argue that “starting with a ceasefire and then negotiating and reaching an agreement is not the same as beginning with a ‘punishment or reward’ strategy (nego-

tiating during war) and then silencing the guns” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 20, author’s translation). This insight is central to the causal mechanism of the thesis. Peace talks can reduce some forms of violence by lowering direct confrontation, signaling restraint, or stabilizing territorial boundaries. At the same time, they can increase or transform other forms of coercion if armed groups use negotiations to strengthen local rule, consolidate extortion markets, or regulate civilian behavior under reduced military pressure. The hypothesis of changing violent trends therefore does not assume that peace talks automatically reduce violence; rather, it assumes that they can reconfigure its level, form, and territorial distribution.

In this framework, the count of events should be understood as an approximation of the scale of the problem rather than as a direct measure of the gravity of each act. Counting armed events, homicides, extortion, and related forms of violence captures the population’s exposure to coercive dynamics, even though each event is treated equally in the measurement strategy. The underlying argument is that a reduction in violence should be understood as a reduction across violent repertoires, rather than as a utilitarian exchange in which one violent mechanism is merely replaced by another. In Buenaventura, for example, the decline in homicides during the ceasefire between Los Shottas and Los Espartanos was reportedly accompanied by an increase in forced disappearances (Johnson et al., 2025). This cannot be interpreted as an improvement in the local security situation, although it is also an outcome that this study cannot fully capture. For that reason, the inclusion of multiple categories of violence, treated as equally problematic indicators of coercion, allows for a broader assessment of the effects of the Total Peace policy.

This expectation is especially strong in contexts where armed groups possess significant territorial control and differentiated forms of governance. Johnson et al. (2025) show that these forms vary sharply across the three study areas. In Arauca, “ELN governance is the most intense and extensive of the three cases” (p. 23, author’s translation), and later the report notes that “every aspect of peasant society was mediated and regulated by the ELN’s local structures” (p. 37, author’s translation).

In Buenaventura, by contrast, Los Shottas and Los Espartanos “control the extortion market and security on cocaine trafficking routes, but do not intervene much more in the life of the local population” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 24, author’s translation), even though they maintain control over “the neighborhoods where they operated” (p. 33, author’s translation). Tumaco occupies

an intermediate but regionalized position: armed regulation extends across “the region, including Tumaco, Barbacoas, Ricaurte and other municipalities” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 41, author’s translation), while “violence in the region did not cease; rather, it shifted to the municipalities north of Tumaco” (p. 44, author’s translation).

These differences matter because, as Moreno León (2017) argues, “the reaction of armed actors toward demonstrations depends on both the target of those mobilizations and the level of control that armed actors exert over the territory” (p. 4). Violence should therefore be expected to respond differently to peace talks depending on whether negotiations occur in a fragmented criminal setting, a consolidated insurgent order, or a region where armed governance is expanding through pacts and territorial reorganization. The framework also implies that resource income conditions both governance and violence.

In Arauca, Johnson et al. (2025) write that “the military strength of the FGO comes from its strong ties to the rural population and its considerable financial resources derived from extortion of the oil industry” (p. 35, author’s translation). In Tumaco, the report explains that armed actors were “motivated, mainly, by the income generated by their control over coca crops and illegal gold mines” (p. 43, author’s translation). These rents help armed organizations sustain coercion, reward followers, and survive negotiation cycles.

For that reason, changes in violent trends during peace talks cannot be understood only as political effects; they must also be read in relation to the economic resources that sustain armed governance. Taken together, this literature supports that violence is a direct manifestation of territorial control, governance, and armed competition, and peace talks may change violent trends because they alter the timing, incentives, and sequencing of coercion. In some settings, negotiations may reduce open violence by freezing conflict or clarifying spheres of control. In others, they may displace violence geographically or transform it into less visible but still coercive practices, such as extortion, civilian intimidation, or selective enforcement. The empirical question of the thesis is therefore not whether peace talks are inherently pacifying, but whether the onset of talks under the Total Peace policy is associated with a change in the level and composition of violence across regions characterized by different forms of armed governance.

Yet, the studies around violence and its evolution in the PPT are limited to qualitative studies and descriptive statistics. The most thorough research initiative has been done by Johnson et al.

(2025) from the SOCACE (Serious Organised Crime & Anti-corruption Evidence Research programme) with sponsor from Global Initiative Against Transnational Crime and CORE Foundation. The authors have been following the policy since it was first implemented, and they have described this new approach as one that “promotes simultaneous negotiations with criminal organizations and political armed groups in order to establish a complete peace” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 7, author’s translation). Johnson’s articles and other evaluation initiatives tend to conclude that the policy is either a failure or its impact is heavily limited.

This is aligned with Valencia and Serrano who reinforce this point by arguing that, in the contemporary conflict, “ideology gave way to a much more pragmatic vision of the country, its regions, and war,” so that cooperation and confrontation among armed actors are now better explained by territorial trajectories, material resources, and local alliances than by ideological commitments alone (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, pp. 41-42, author’s translation). At the same time, they warn that this de-ideologization does not imply a purely criminal war, since many supposedly criminal actors remain political insofar as they govern territories, regulate civilians, and intervene in local democratic life (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, pp. 42-43).

Johnson from CORE stand at the position where the policy impact results are limited (Johnson, 2024; Johnson et. al 2025), which aligns with different older reports that show some overall decreases in violence across cities like Buenaventura (FIP, 2024). However, these results are contrasted with more recent evidence that portrays increased violence across the country (Ambos, 2026; Preciado, 2026) and the later report from FIP that showcases how the violence has aggravated during 2025 and 2026 (Cajiao, 2026). In general, research sources point towards limited effects to the policy and even missing instruments for proper impact measurement (Valencia, 2025)

In general, the policy can be analyzed from different sources. Some of the most throughout work comes from InSight Crime, that has an entire series focusing on the milestones of the policy from a journalistic position (see Insight Crime, Series Especiales: Dificultades y Desafíos de la Paz Total en Colombia <https://insightcrime.org/es/noticias/series-especiales/dificultades-desafios-paz-total-colombia/>), or the Fundación Ideas para la Paz interactive dashboard, where the relevant milestones are summarized in a chess table (see FIP, Las Jugadas de la Paz Total <https://multimedia.ideaspaz.org/especial-total/index.html>).

And even, the policy can be analyzed at the yearly reports of Petro’s presidency from the

FIP, where initially expectations seemed to be fairly positive, but on the latest reports the results are lukewarm at most (FIP, 2023; FIP, 2024; FIP, 2025). Some journalistic approaches are less comprehensive, and they label the policy as a failure (Leon, 2026; FIP, 2026) which seems to be aligned with recent declarations from Gustavo Petro who also admitted a policy failure (Swissinfo, 2026). Overall, the panorama does not seem great. However, no literature has yet assessed the impact outside of interviews and people’s perspectives, or a mere description of the latest trends compared in a year to year basis.

This thesis then complements the literature by comparing qualitative results with a causal quantitative analysis. The strength of qualitative research is that it measures the impact of both objective as subjective violence. As, individuals will report their feelings which are aligned to the sociocultural context and shaped by quantitative measurements of objective violence happening on their surroundings. However, it is limited by the fact that people might feel like the situation has changed due to the policy, but it ignores nuances that can be better measured using causal models.

The idea then is that this thesis will use qualitative observations as covariates, generating a final model that can measure the impact of the policy and use both qualitative and quantitative observations across the selected cases. One example is that the killing of one of the gang leaders son’s in Buenaventura starts a dispute (clash). This pushes an increase in the homicides during 2023 even with active negotiations (Johnson, 2026). This change affects people’s perspectives into thinking that the policy is a failure, whereas this same event serves as a control and interaction for the model that allows to track how the policy impacts when there are active clashes between armed groups in a municipality.

The nature of Buenaventura conflict is quite particular. Gangs fight for urban control, gather money from extorting and the sale of cocaine that is smuggled into the port or is sent to the north in semi-submersibles. In this sense, gangs are established as control entities inside the neighborhoods, but their control mechanisms are limited to these specific areas. Both objective and subjective violence are prominent in the city. And the levels of violence are generally high and directed towards civilian population: homicides, extortion, civilian targeting, terrorism and even curfews (Sánchez-Garzoli, 2024).

Tumaco, on the other hand, is one of the main production and export clusters of cocaine in the country where the conflict between armed groups has been active since the 90’s (Johnson, 2025).

These groups are well established in the region, they depend mainly on cocaine and gold, and hence their actions shift based on their resource portfolio (Rettberg, 2016; Crisis Group, 2019). The strong presence and establishment allows the groups to control the territory without inquiring in objective violence. Although the clashes are permanent, the violent trends in the region are downgrading.

On the same line, Arauca's case is also qualitatively explained. The well established ELN has received a military incursion since 2022 due to an expansionist leader on from the competing Frente de Guerra Oriental (FGO) since the initiation of peace talks with the government. So even with active negotiations, the incursion of other groups are pushing up the general observations of violent crimes. ELN has presence on several departments, but their horizontal structure keeps them relatively separated from their counterparts in other regions (Aguilera, 2006). In Arauca ELN relies mostly on coca production, immigrant smuggling and oil. The groups has shown great interest in continuing a peace process, but internal fights, and clashes with other groups are giving varied results. It is not clear if the peace negotiations are reducing the violence in the region.

With the aforementioned, there are limits to how to measure subjective violence. And the best approaches are usually qualitative and based on human perspectives. In this regard, prior studies have concluded that PPT has likely failed to reduce objective and subjective violence across the regions, and the timing of the negotiations could have even propitiated the military expansion of specific groups. In order to test these claims, this thesis will focus in understanding how PPT has affected objective violence, by tracing a causal path between the treatment and the counted observations of political violence, civilian targeting, homicides, terrorism and extortion. And by doing so, it will trace if in fact the negotiation timeline has led to a change in observable violence levels, or if there is not enough evidence to deny or accept current qualitative results.

3 Research Design

3.1 Research Question

Within Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco what is the association between the timing of Petro's Total Peace policy (2022-2026) negotiations and the monthly incidence of conflict-related events (homicide, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting, and political violence)?

Null Hypothesis (H0): The initiation of formal peace talks in a municipality has no statistically

significant association with the monthly frequency of specific conflict-related events.

3.2 Methodology and Variables

Methodologically, the study uses panel data and estimates two-way fixed-effects models. Two-way fixed models are a preferred tool as they enable us to address confounding biases that are unobservable but are common to all observed units (Dayal and Murugesan, 2023). In this case, the geographical level fixed effects account for unobserved time-invariant heterogeneity, while time fixed effects absorb time-varying (Dayal and Murugesan, 2023). Applied to this study, territorial-case fixed effects absorb time-invariant characteristics of each case, including geography, long-run armed-group presence, and local institutional structure, while month fixed effects absorb shocks common to all cases, such as macro-political changes, seasonality, and countrywide security dynamics. The identifying logic is therefore within-case overtime comparison: the model tests whether violence changes once peace talks begin in a given case, net of permanent differences across territories and common shocks affecting all territories in the same month.

The panel-data is composed of Colombia’s violent trends across three subnational cases: Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco, measured as the monthly count of violent events. This choice treats event counts as an indicator of the frequency with which local populations are exposed to coercive practices. This is especially important in settings where peace talks may reduce one form of violence while displacing it into another. For that reason, the analysis uses both an aggregate and disaggregated outcome.

The disaggregated outcome is composed of 5 variables. Three of them, **homicides**, **terrorism**, and **extortion** come from police reports aggregated to the monthly level. Two additional variables come from ACLED and are likewise converted to monthly counts. **civilian_targeting** measures the monthly count of reported civilian targeting events. According to the ACLED dataset definition, civilian targeting includes violence against civilians events and explosions/remote violence events in which civilians were directly targeted. Whereas **political_violence** includes battles, violence against civilians, explosions/remote violence, and the mob violence sub-event type within riots. The set of variables are used as monthly counts of observed events rather than fatalities, and both are harmonized to the same case-month structure. Whereas, the aggregated variable is just the addition of these five components.

The outcome variable is a non-negative integer count of monthly events, which has implications for model specification that are addressed more fully in the robustness analysis. Cameron and Trivedi (2013) emphasize that count outcomes are typically right-skewed and overdispersed, with variance that grows with the mean, characteristics that violate the homoscedasticity assumption underlying ordinary least squares. While OLS coefficients remain unbiased estimates of average treatment effects under panel fixed-effects designs, standard errors and inferential statistics may be affected by the distributional features of count data. The thesis therefore retains Fixed Effect OLS as the main specification given its standard place in difference-in-differences applications and the directness of its event-count interpretation, but verifies the substantive findings against a Difference-in-Difference, Poisson and negative binomial specifications appropriate for count outcomes.

The mechanism of interest is whether the beginning of negotiations alters the strategic incentives of armed actors and is therefore associated with changes in the level of observed violence. As Johnson et al. argue, “timing and sequencing are key factors in the development of dialogue processes” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 6, author’s translation), and the implementation of *Paz Total* opened “a window of opportunity for the emergence, resurgence, or reconfiguration of rebel or criminal forms of governance” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 21, author’s translation). In the data, this mechanism is expressed as a change in monthly violent trends after the onset of peace talks relative to the pre-treatment period.

The main explanatory variable is **treatment**, a binary indicator coded as 1 during the months in which the peace talks (tables) or formal negotiation processes were active in a given territorial case, and 0 otherwise. The treatment is not defined as a final agreement, a ceasefire outcome, or a successful demobilization, but rather as the period during which negotiations were underway under the framework of the PPT, or based on the armed group agreeing to begin the negotiations and had started reducing military actions even if the table hadn’t officially begun.

The coding of treatment periods relies primarily on Johnson et al. (2025), and news portals. In Arauca, the treatment begins in August 2022, when negotiations with the ELN resumed under the Petro administration (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 35), and is coded as ending in September 2024, when the process was suspended following the ELN attack on a military base in Arauca (*El Colombiano*, 2024). In Tumaco, the treatment begins in June 2024, when formal talks with the Segunda Marquetalia began and included the operational units in Tumaco (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 43).

The treatment remains active through the end of the observed period because subsequent public reporting indicates continued dialogue with successor structures (Frente Guerrillero Oriental) linked to that process (*El País*, 2025; *La Silla Vacía*, 2025). In Buenaventura, the treatment begins in September 2022, following the initiation of the preliminary negotiation phase between Los Shottas and Los Espartanos under the broader *Paz Total* framework (Johnson et al., 2025, pp. 29–30).

A central extension of the baseline design is the inclusion of time-varying control for armed-group dispute. The variable *Clash* is coded as a binary indicator equal to 1 in months in which a territorial case is experiencing active inter-group conflict and 0 otherwise. This control is included because changes in violence may reflect not only negotiation dynamics but also shifts in territorial confrontation among armed organizations. In substantive terms, control is especially important for Arauca, where violence rises in the context of an intensifying dispute beginning in January 2022 (Celis, 2026), and for Buenaventura, where the intensity of confrontation changes across periods of conflict and truce (SAGA UNODC, 2024; Reynoso, 2025; RTVC, 2025). Tumaco is coded as exposed to persistent inter-group conflict throughout the observed period. Including this variable helps separate the association between peace talks and violence from the association between violence and active armed dispute.

The study adopts a case-based territorial panel rather than a nationally pooled design because the relevant variation is local and because the territorial scale of armed governance differs across cases. This is based on two facts, one is the policy design itself, the Total Peace Policy “focuses on how local governance dynamics influence the implementation of Total Peace and highlights how they differ according to the local conditions of each region” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 7, author’s translation). And second, as Colombia cannot be studied as a homogeneous region. The country is composed by several regions, that are built as oppositions of the “center”. These, are a complex puzzle that has unique ways of governance, crime and even culture (Serge, 2006).

Accordingly, the unit of analysis is a territorial case-month. Buenaventura is modeled as a municipality-level case because criminal control is concentrated within the city (Insight Crime, 2025). Arauca is modeled at the departmental scale because the relevant armed order extends across the department and is shaped primarily by the Frente Domingo Laín (Insight Crime, 2026). Tumaco is modeled as a regional cluster because armed governance and violence spill across adjacent municipalities (Insight Crime, 2025b). This territorial definition is methodological rather than

merely descriptive: it seeks to align the spatial scale of the data with the spatial scale at which armed control and negotiation effects are most likely to operate.

These cases are not treated as interchangeable. Rather, they are approached as territorially distinct expressions of Colombia's contemporary armed conflict, each shaped by a different configuration of governance, dispute, and spatial reach. ?? illustrates this first territorial distinction by locating the broader geography of armed spillovers and conflict dynamics in which the three cases are embedded. In line with Valencia and Serrano's argument that the contemporary Colombian war is increasingly subnational, the map shows that violence is not organized through a single national conflict line, but through localized and regionalized patterns of dispute, coexistence, and dominance (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, pp. 44-45).

The violent mechanisms will be hence explained in different contexts of violence: a rebelocracy (Arjona, 2016) in the case of Arauca, as ELN has been present and taken over power from several years. Criminal Governance in Buenaventura, as Los Shottas and Espartanos are controlling, collecting taxes, defining geographical boundaries and punishing through different mechanisms as explained in Johnson (2025). And finally, the intermediate case of Tumaco, that is a criminal governance from a rebel group that has come to certain agreements with local authorities that would make it to some extent an aliocracy.

?? complements this discussion by showing the territorial relationship between homicide rates and illicit economies, especially coca cultivation and cocaine seizures. While the national homicide rate may appear relatively stable in aggregate terms, the regional distribution of lethal violence is highly uneven. In 2024, departments such as Arauca, Cauca, Valle del Cauca, Putumayo, and Chocó recorded some of the highest homicide rates in the country, concentrating violence in peripheral and border territories.

When these patterns are read together with the geography of illicit economies, a clearer territorial logic emerges: violence tends to cluster where armed actors compete for control over strategic corridors, rent-generating markets, and local populations. This is particularly visible in southwestern and Pacific regions, where coca cultivation, trafficking routes, and fragmented armed orders overlap.

Map 2 therefore does not merely describe a correlation between illegality and violence; it helps illustrate the political economy of territorial competition that underlies the persistence of armed conflict in places such as Tumaco and, in a different form, Arauca. Taken together, Maps 1 and 2

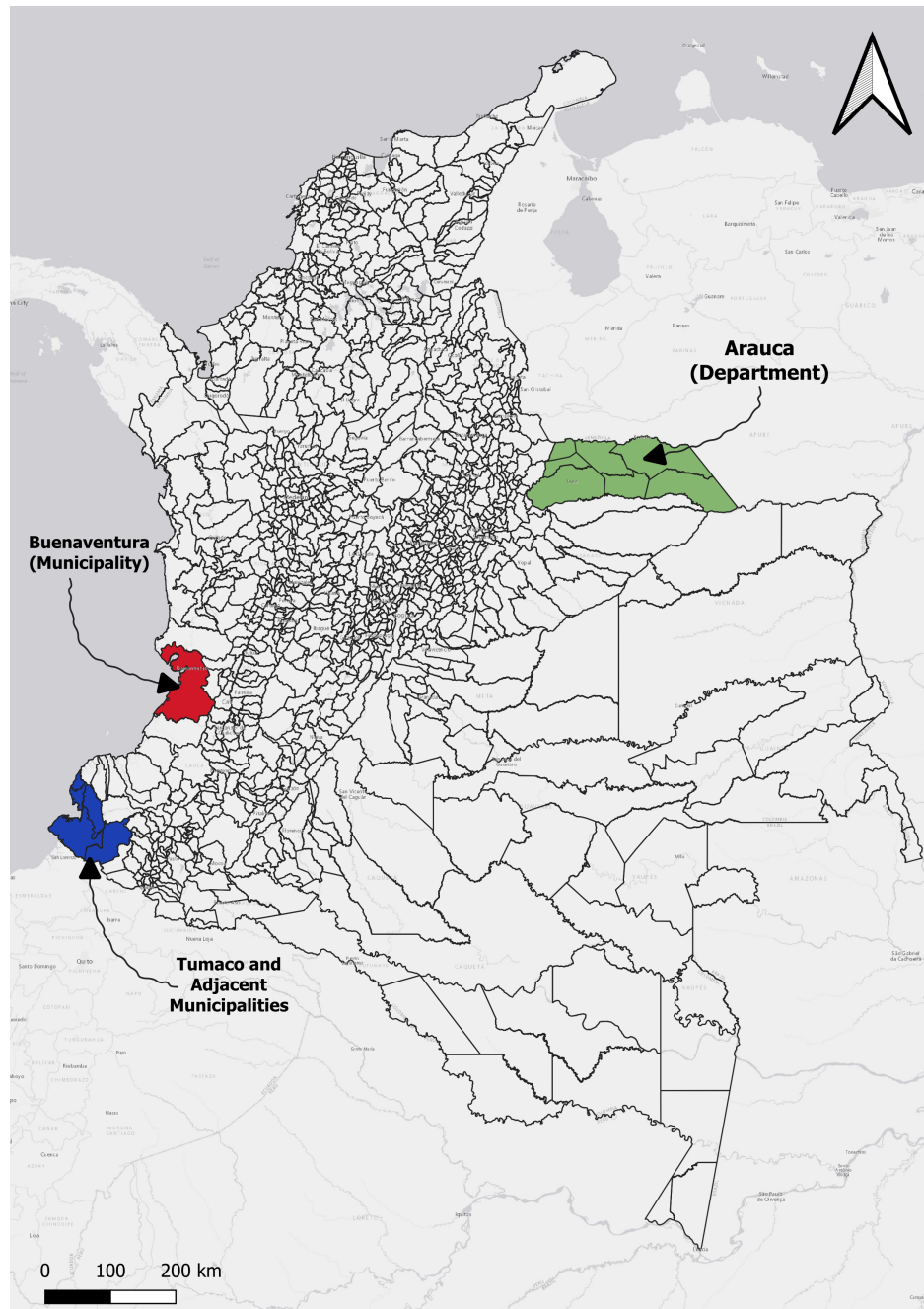


Figure 1: Selected areas for analysis. Source: Prepared by the author with ESRI basemap

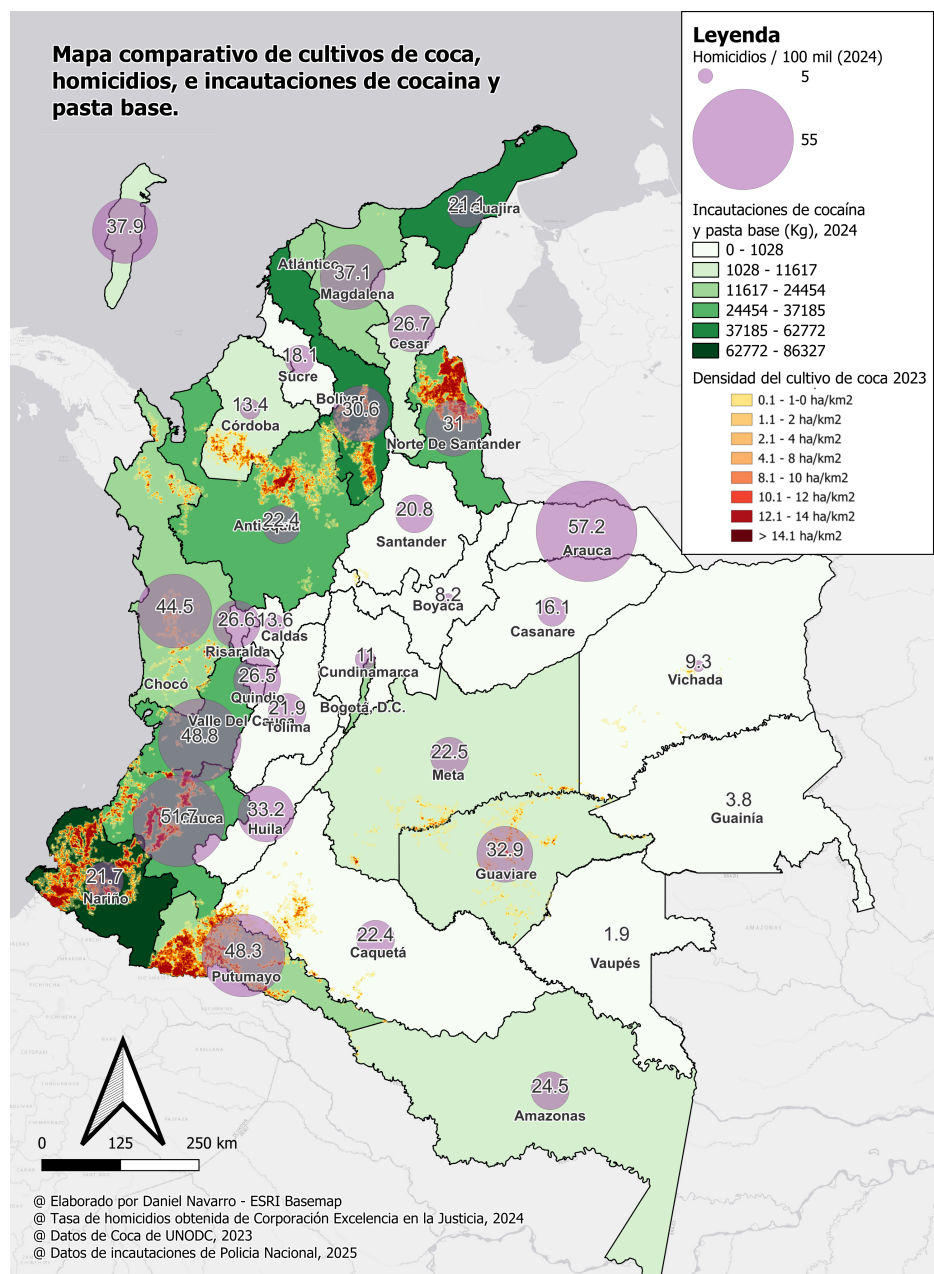


Figure 2: Cocaine, Seizures and Homicides National, Navarro and Valencia, 2025. Source: Prepared by the author and published on Valencia, 2025

provide complementary justification for the case selection and spatial design of the thesis. Map 1 situates the three cases within broader patterns of armed spillover, regional dispute, and differentiated territorial governance. Map 2 shows that these same territories are also shaped by the spatial concentration of illicit economies, which increase their strategic value for armed actors and help sustain violent competition. The two maps thus reinforce the same analytical point from different angles: Colombia’s contemporary war is territorially uneven, regionally interconnected, and deeply linked to localized forms of armed governance and illegal accumulation.

The baseline specification is:

$$Violence_{it} = \alpha_i + \lambda_t + \beta Treatment_{it} + \delta Clash_{it} + \theta (Treatment_{it} \times Clash_{it}) + \varepsilon_{it}$$

where $Violence_{it}$ is the monthly count of violent events in territorial unit i and month t , α_i are territorial-case fixed effects, λ_t are month fixed effects, $Treatment_{it}$ equals 1 in months in which peace talks are active in that case, and $Clash_{it}$ equals 1 in months with active armed-group dispute. In this specification, β captures the association between peace talks and monthly violence in case-months without active dispute, conditional on both fixed effects. The coefficient δ captures the association between active armed dispute and violence in non-treatment months, net of negotiations and fixed effects. The interaction coefficient, θ , captures the additional association when peace talks and active armed dispute occur simultaneously. In substantive terms, the interaction term allows the model to assess whether the association between treatment and violence differs between periods with and without clashes.

This design addresses the main sources of bias that fixed effects are intended to absorb. Armed governance, territorial control, and local institutional capacity are highly persistent over time and are therefore plausibly captured by territorial-case fixed effects. At the same time, common national developments, including changes in the broader implementation of PPT, military strategy, or macro-political shocks, are absorbed by month fixed effects. The inclusion of the armed-dispute dummy additionally accounts for a substantively important time-varying source of violence that would otherwise risk confounding the treatment effect. As a result, the empirical strategy isolates whether the negotiation period is associated with a deviation from the prior violent trend within each case,

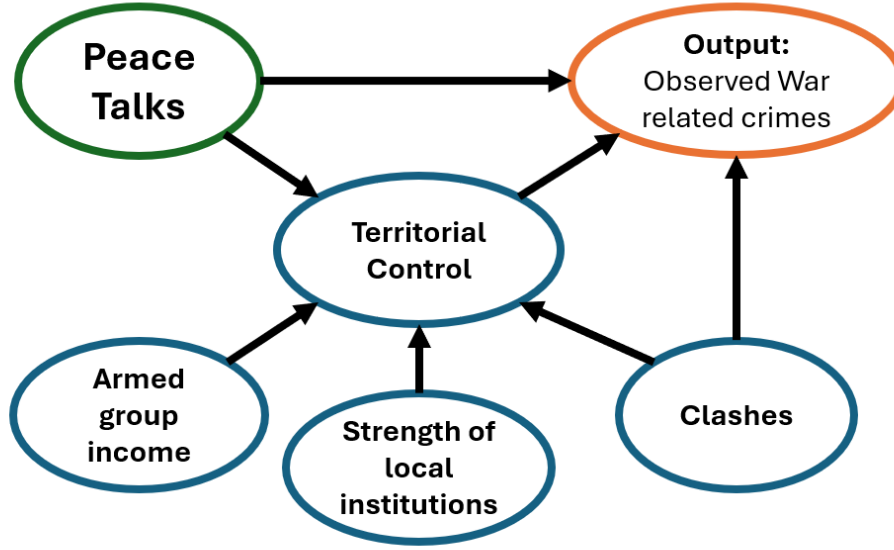


Figure 3: Causal Path: Peace Talks affect the Output (Observed War Related Crimes) and the territorial control. Territorial control affects the violent trends in the region, but mainly depends on the overall strength of the armed group, the civilian resistance and the clashes with other groups. Clashes, are affecting the outcome and the territorial control.

net of both enduring territorial characteristics and contemporaneous conflict dynamics. Standard errors are clustered at the territorial-case level, although inference must be interpreted cautiously given the small number of units. The design addresses the causal path as displayed in figure 1.

3.3 Assumptions

The first identifying assumption is that, conditional on territorial-case fixed effects, month fixed effects, and the inclusion of `clash_dummy`, there are no omitted case-specific time-varying shocks that both affect the onset of peace talks and independently alter violence in the same period. This is the key assumption that makes the treatment coefficient interpretable as a within-case association rather than a simple coincidence. It is plausible to the extent that the most important persistent differences across cases are absorbed by α_i , and the most important common shocks are absorbed by λ_t . The inclusion of `clash_dummy` strengthens this design by accounting for months in which active armed-group dispute is likely to affect violence independently of the negotiation process. However, the assumption would still be threatened if, for example, a major local security shock in one case simultaneously triggered negotiations and altered violence through a separate channel that is not

fully captured by the observed clash measure.

A second assumption is limited anticipation. Armed actors should not systematically change their violent behavior long before the effective onset of peace talks in ways that would already embed the treatment effect in the pre-treatment period. This is addressed by initiating the treatment period once the actors agreed to participate and acted accordingly, rather than when the negotiation table effectively begun.

A third assumption is that spillovers across the three territorial cases are limited enough not to invalidate the within-case comparison. This is addressed in the geographical specification. Moreno’s argument is useful here because he shows that armed actors’ responses depend on “the level of control that armed actors exert over the territory” (Moreno León, 2017, p. 4). If territorial control and violent responses shift across neighboring areas in direct response to negotiations, part of the observed effect may reflect displacement rather than a pure local treatment effect. Hence the importance of generating a regional cluster depending on the group’s presence.

Finally, the specification assumes that the treatment effect is modeled as an average additive shift during peace-talk months. This does not mean that the substantive process is simple. On the contrary, the theoretical framework suggests that negotiations may reduce some forms of violence but shifting to other under-reported ones such as forced disappearance. What the additive TWFE coefficient captures is the average change in aggregate monthly violence associated with the negotiation period, not the full complexity of all underlying mechanisms. In the same way, the inclusion of `clash_dummy` should not be interpreted as fully modeling the entire strategic structure of armed confrontation. Rather, it controls for one observable dimension of conflict intensity so that the treatment coefficient is less likely to absorb violent changes driven primarily by ongoing armed dispute.

This identification strategy is plausible for three main reasons. First, qualitative evidence suggests that the timing of peace talks was not determined solely by short-run local fluctuations in violence. Johnson et al. (2025) show that the onset of negotiations was shaped by a combination of national political windows, local security crises, and the willingness of armed groups to negotiate. In methodological terms, these sources of variation do not all threaten identification equally. National political windows, such as the launch and prioritization of PPT affected all cases and are therefore absorbed by month fixed effects. Local security crises are included in the design through

the `clash_dummy`, limited to public information availability. Armed-group willingness to negotiate is more difficult to observe directly, but to the extent that it reflects durable organizational and territorial characteristics, much of it is captured by territorial-case fixed effects. For these reasons, the timing of treatment is unlikely to be systematically driven by unobserved shocks that operate identically across all three cases.

Second, the potential role of armed-group income is compatible with the fixed-effects strategy. Gold and cocaine prices are determined in international markets and cannot plausibly be caused by the onset of peace talks in Buenaventura, Arauca, or Tumaco. In that sense, reverse causality from local negotiations to global prices is not a realistic concern. The more relevant question is whether changes in international prices may affect local violence and, indirectly, the strategic incentives surrounding negotiations. This is theoretically possible. However, because these price series are common to all cases within each month, their confounding role is addressed through month fixed effects in the baseline model.

Third, the fixed-effects design is well suited to the main confounders identified in the literature on Colombian armed conflict. Persistent differences in institutional quality, state presence, territorial control, and local social organization are central to explaining violent variation across territories. Arjona (2016) shows that local institutional strength shapes how armed actors govern and how communities resist them, while Gutiérrez Sanín and Barón (2006) emphasize the importance of territorial control and armed order in structuring violent dynamics. These are precisely the types of factors that are likely to remain relatively stable within a territorial case over the study period and are therefore absorbed by α_i , the territorial-case fixed effects. Likewise, broader policy changes and common national shocks are absorbed by λ_t , the month fixed effects. In this setting, the empirical strategy therefore isolates whether violence changes within a case once peace talks are underway, net of permanent territorial differences, common monthly shocks, and the observed timing of active armed-group dispute.

At the same time, the design is not free from threats. One possible concern is omitted variable bias from local shocks that coincide with the negotiation period and independently affect violence. This risk is especially relevant in highly localized and fluid urban settings such as Buenaventura, where short-run shifts in gang organization, neighborhood-level competition, or enforcement practices may alter violent trends independently of the talks. The inclusion of `clash_dummy` helps

address this concern, but it cannot eliminate it completely because not every local shock takes the form of an observable clash period. Tumaco is permanently exposed to clash as this violent dynamics are constant and under-reported. The risk may be lower in Arauca, where armed governance is more territorially consolidated, but it cannot be ruled out.

For these reasons, the two-way fixed-effects model should not be understood as proving exogeneity, nor as fully eliminating all threats to causal inference. Rather, it makes the identifying assumption more plausible by accounting for the most important sources of confounding highlighted in both the substantive and methodological literature. The resulting estimates should therefore be interpreted as theoretically informed within-case comparisons over time. They provide credible evidence on whether violent trends changed during the period in which peace talks were active, while still requiring caution about local omitted shocks, treatment timing, spillovers, and the very small number of territorial cases.

4 Exploratory Data Analysis

The exploratory analysis examines two questions before turning to the regression results. First, whether the descriptive distribution of monthly violent events is consistent with the analytical assumption that peace talks may reconfigure rather than uniformly reduce violence. Second, whether the descriptive evidence supports including the interaction between treatment and clash status as a substantively meaningful component of the empirical strategy.

The monthly panel covers January 2018 to March 2026, with 297 territorial-case-month observations distributed across Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco. Across the full sample the average monthly count of total events is 31.07, with a standard deviation of 22.74 and a maximum of 137 events. As table 1 already showed, the three cases enter the period of analysis at very different baseline levels. Arauca exhibits the highest average monthly violence and the largest dispersion, Buenaventura sits in an intermediate range, and Tumaco shows the lowest mean count. These differences are consistent with the territorial heterogeneity emphasized in the theoretical framework, where each case represents a distinct configuration of armed governance: a consolidated insurgent order in Arauca, a fragmented criminal governance in Buenaventura, and a regionalized armed control structure in Tumaco.

4.1 National and departmental context

Before focusing on the three study cases, it is important to situate them within the broader national distribution of violence. Figure 4 presents monthly counts of each violence type across all Colombian departments, with Arauca, Nariño (where Tumaco is located), Valle del Cauca (where Buenaventura is located), and the national average highlighted against the rest of the country.

The figure reveals two patterns that justify the case-based design of the thesis. First, Valle del Cauca stands out as a national outlier in homicide and extortion counts, reflecting the concentration of urban criminal markets that includes Buenaventura but extends far beyond the municipality itself. Second, the violent dynamics of Arauca and Nariño remain closer to the national average in absolute terms, but they exhibit different trajectories than the rest of the country, particularly in political violence and civilian targeting. These departmental trajectories support the analytical decision to study the three cases as territorially distinct units rather than as elements of a homogeneous national process. The aggregate national patterns also confirm that violence in Colombia remains regionally uneven and persistent throughout the observed period, which is consistent with the literature reviewed in the introduction.

4.2 Distribution and total exposure across cases

Figure 5 presents the marginal distribution of monthly counts for each violence type within each case. The distributions are heavily right-skewed and bounded at zero, with most months concentrated near low values and a small number of months showing extreme counts. This shape is consistent across cases and across violence types, although the magnitudes differ substantially.

In Arauca, all five violence types show meaningful dispersion, with homicide reaching the highest values. In Buenaventura, extortion and homicide concentrate the bulk of the variation, while political violence and terrorism remain relatively rare. In Tumaco, the distributions are the most concentrated near zero, with occasional spikes in political violence and civilian targeting. The shape of these distributions raises an early concern about the appropriateness of ordinary least squares for the outcome variable. Cameron and Trivedi (2013) emphasize that count outcomes with this kind of skewness and overdispersion typically require Poisson or negative binomial specifications to respect the structural features of the data. Section 6 retains OLS as the main specification because the

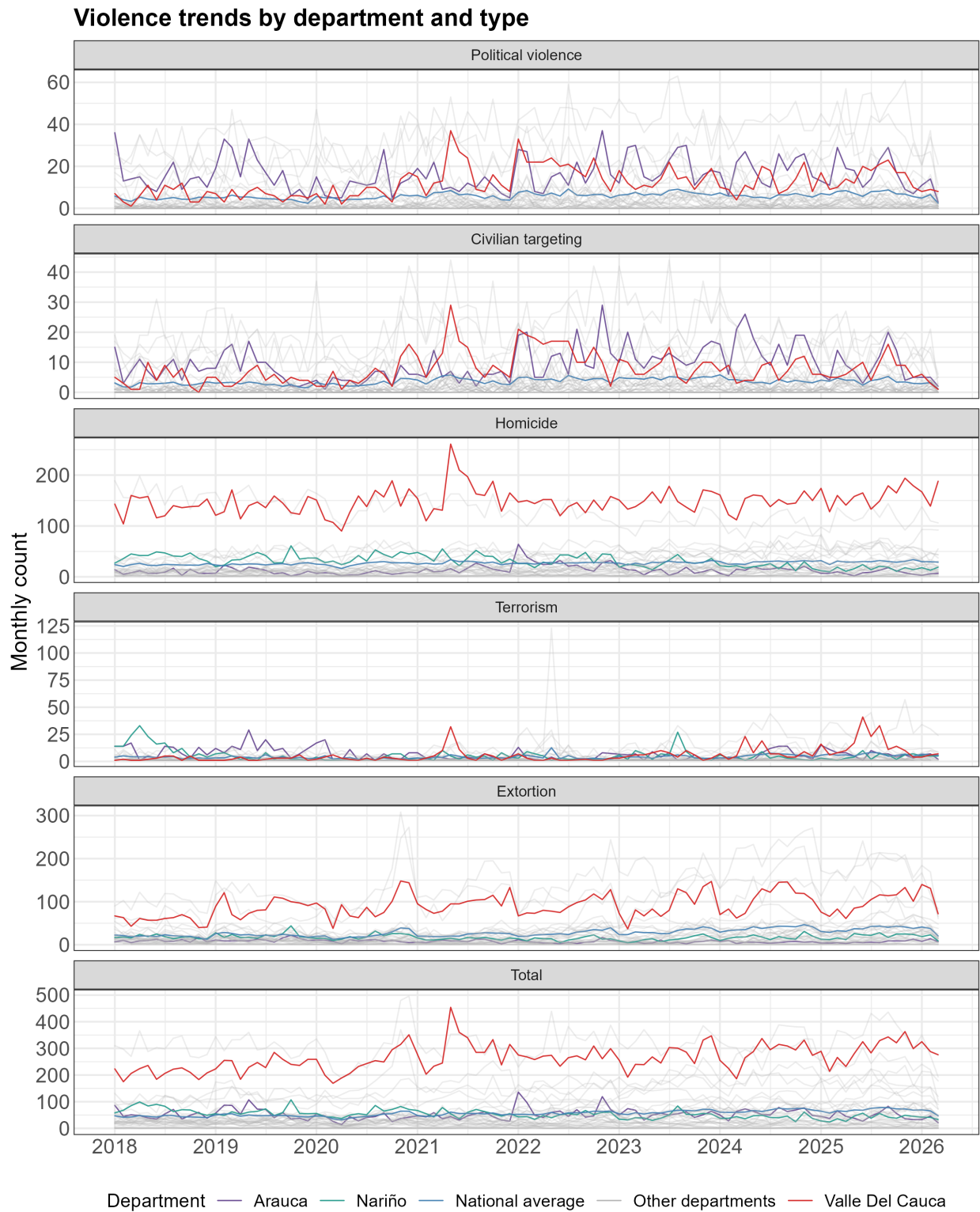


Figure 4: Violence trends by department and type, January 2018 to March 2026. Source: Prepared by the author with ACLED and Policía Nacional de Colombia data.

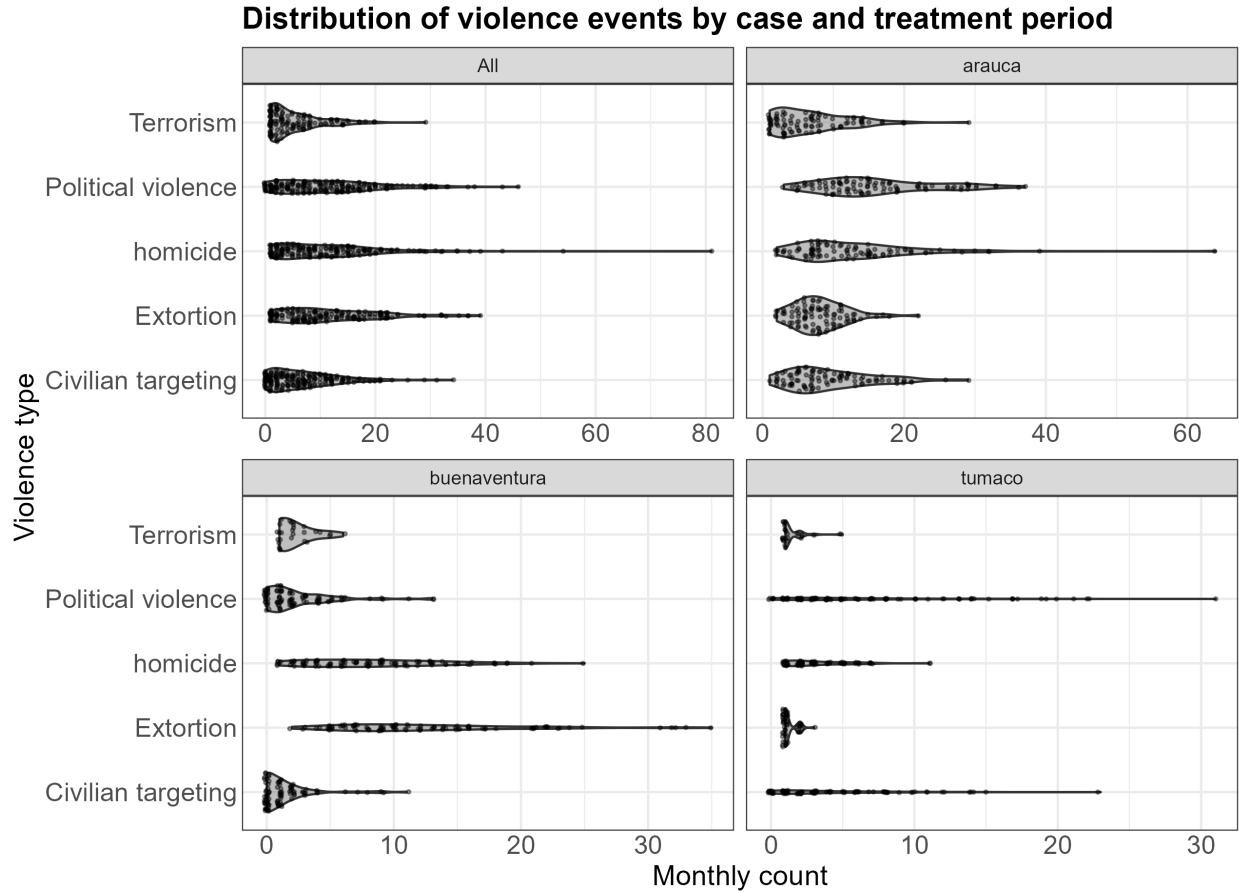


Figure 5: Distribution of monthly violence events by case and violence type. Source: Prepared by the author with ACLED and Policía Nacional de Colombia data.

panel structure and fixed-effects design absorb most of the within-case variance, but the appendix includes Poisson and negative binomial estimations as robustness checks against the distributional features visible here.

Figure 6 aggregates total event counts within each case and divides them between treated and untreated periods. The figure provides a direct visual comparison of how the volume of each violence type changed before and after the onset of peace talks.

The patterns differ substantially across cases. In Arauca, the untreated period accumulated higher totals of homicide, extortion, civilian targeting, and terrorism, while the treated period concentrated more heavily on political violence. In Buenaventura, the treated period shows lower totals of extortion and homicide compared to the untreated period, but a higher relative share of political violence. In Tumaco, the treated period concentrates almost all observable activity in

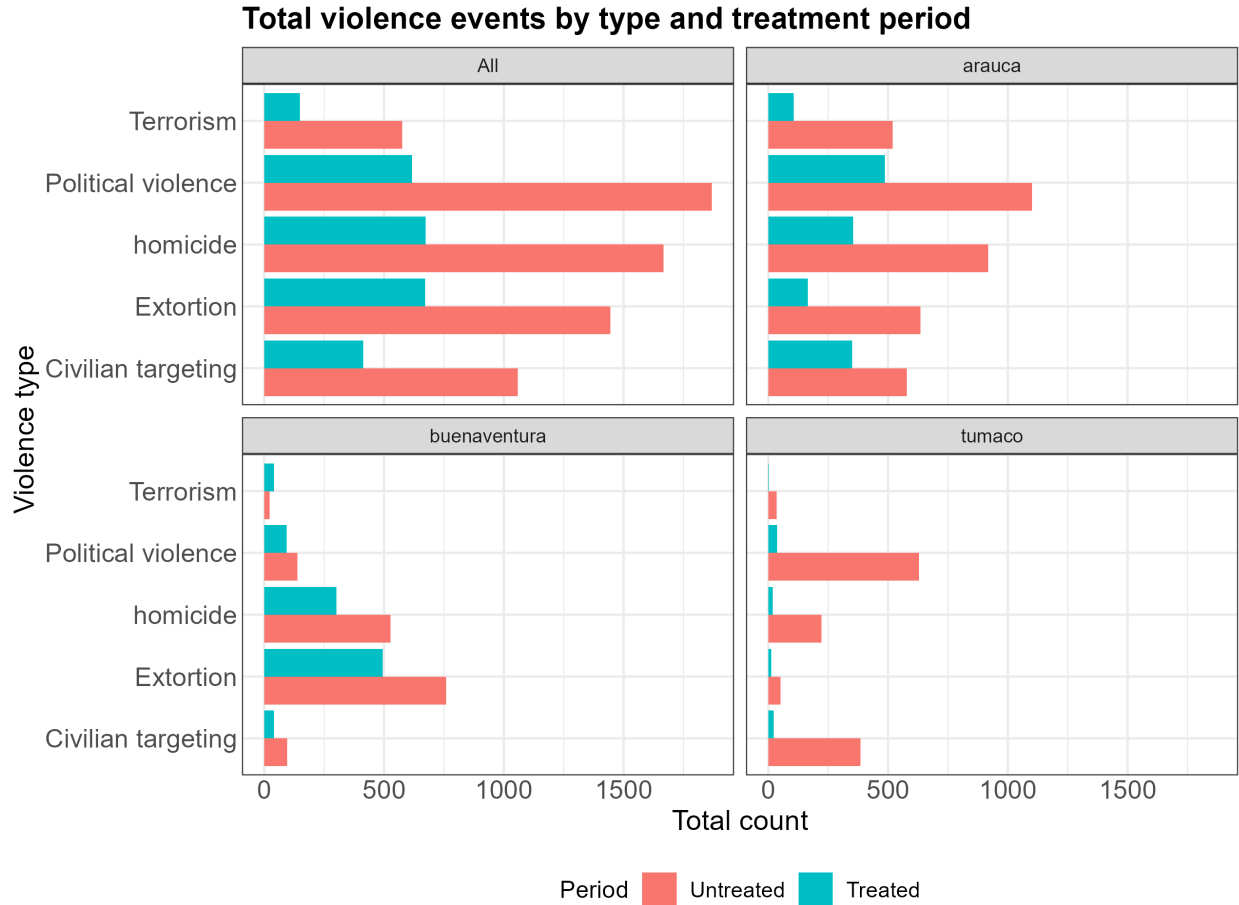


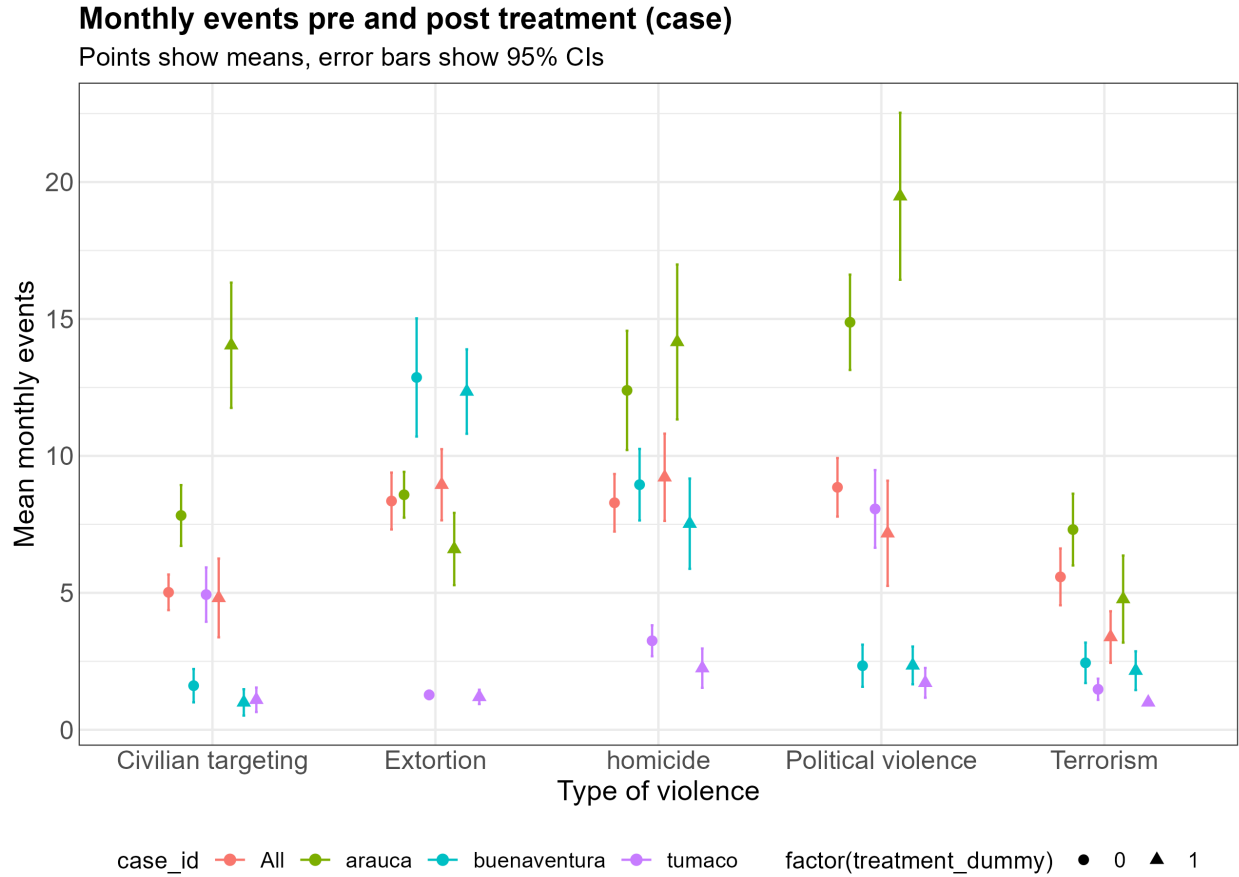
Figure 6: Total violence events by type and treatment period across cases. Source: Prepared by the author with ACLED and Policía Nacional de Colombia data.

political violence and civilian targeting, with very low counts in homicide, extortion, and terrorism. The aggregated panel ("All") combines these heterogeneous patterns and shows that the dominant violence type during treatment shifted toward political violence across the three cases combined. The figure does not control for the different lengths of the treatment and untreated windows, which differ across cases, but it offers a useful descriptive complement to the regression analysis.

4.3 Within-case change and the case-specific direction of treatment

Figure 7 presents pre-treatment and post-treatment means of each violence type for each case, with 95 percent confidence intervals that show the within-case change from the pre-treatment to the treatment period.

The figure makes the heterogeneity across cases visually evident. In Arauca, the within-case



Source: ACLED and Policía Nacional de Colombia

Figure 7: Monthly events pre and post treatment, by case and violence type. Source: Prepared by the author with ACLED and Policía Nacional de Colombia data.

change is positive for civilian targeting, homicide, and political violence, with the largest increase concentrated in political violence. Extortion and terrorism show smaller or marginal changes in the same case. In Buenaventura, civilian targeting and political violence show modest increases, while homicide remains roughly stable and terrorism declines slightly. The Buenaventura case also illustrates the small magnitude of changes in absolute terms, which reflects the lower overall baseline of violence relative to Arauca. In Tumaco, all violence types decline during the treatment period, although the confidence intervals are wide and the changes are modest in absolute terms.

These divergent trajectories provide an early visual argument for the within-case identification strategy. If the three cases responded uniformly to peace talks, a pooled comparison would be sufficient. The fact that the pre-post lines move in different directions across cases motivates the inclusion of case fixed effects, which absorb the cross-case differences in baseline violence and isolate

the within-case change associated with the negotiation period.

4.4 The interaction between treatment and clash status

Figure 8 presents the four-cell structure that the regression interaction term formalizes. Mean monthly counts are computed for each combination of treatment status and clash status, with 95 percent confidence intervals attached to each point and lines connecting the cells that share a clash condition.

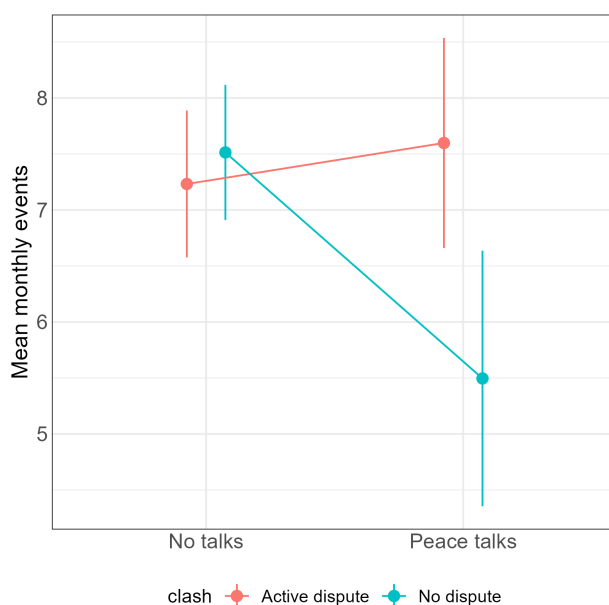


Figure 8: Mean monthly events by treatment status and active armed-group dispute. Source: Prepared by the author with ACLED and Policía Nacional de Colombia data.

The figure shows that the slope of the line corresponding to no active dispute differs from the slope of the line corresponding to active dispute. In months without active dispute, mean violence drops from approximately 7.5 events under no talks to approximately 5.5 events during peace talks. In months with active dispute, mean violence remains roughly stable across treatment conditions, moving from around 7.2 to 7.6 events. The two lines therefore cross, which is the descriptive signature of an interaction effect.

This pattern is theoretically meaningful. The decline in the no-dispute condition suggests that peace talks may reduce violence in contexts where armed groups are not actively confronting each other. The flat line in the active-dispute condition suggests that this reduction is offset, or absent,

when armed groups are simultaneously engaged in territorial confrontation. The figure provides the descriptive justification for retaining the interaction specification as the preferred model, and it anticipates the regression results in section 6. And it highlights the importance of local dynamics when opening a peace talk that might lead to military incursions from rival groups.

A simple two-sample comparison reinforces this point. A t-test of monthly violence counts between treatment and non-treatment months across the pooled sample yields a small and statistically insignificant difference. When the comparison is repeated separately for clash-active and clash-inactive months, the means diverge in the direction shown in figure 8, which is consistent with the descriptive evidence and the regression results presented below.

4.5 Summary of exploratory evidence

Taken together, the exploratory evidence suggests three things. The cases differ in their baseline levels and in their trajectories during the negotiation period, which justifies the within-case identification strategy. The relationship between peace talks and violence appears to depend on clash status, which justifies the interaction term in the regression specification. And the count distribution of the outcome motivates the count-data robustness checks reported in the results section.

5 Results

This section presents the regression results from the empirical strategy described in 3.2. The discussion centers on answering, if within Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco there is an association between the timing of peace talks or negotiations and the monthly incidence of conflict-related events (homicide, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting, and political violence). The full regression tables are available in the appendix. The main specification reports IID standard errors, and the robustness section addresses the alternative count-data specifications and the cluster-robust standard errors.

The presentation follows the same logical sequence as the empirical strategy. First, the pooled OLS results establish a descriptive baseline. Second, the case fixed-effects models incorporate the within-case identification logic. Third, the two-way fixed-effects models add month fixed effects to absorb common shocks. Fourth, the disaggregated outcome models examine whether the ag-

gregate findings are driven by particular forms of violence. Robustness checks against count-data specifications close the section.

5.1 Pooled OLS

The pooled OLS coefficients are presented in figure 9. In the simplest specification with treatment alone, the association between peace talks and aggregate monthly violence is statistically indistinguishable from zero. Adding the clash control does not substantially alter this result. When the interaction term is introduced, the treatment coefficient becomes negative and statistically significant at the ten percent level, while the interaction coefficient is positive and significant at the same level. These pooled estimates suggest that, on average, peace talks are associated with lower violence in the absence of active clashes, and that the association attenuates or reverses when clashes are active.

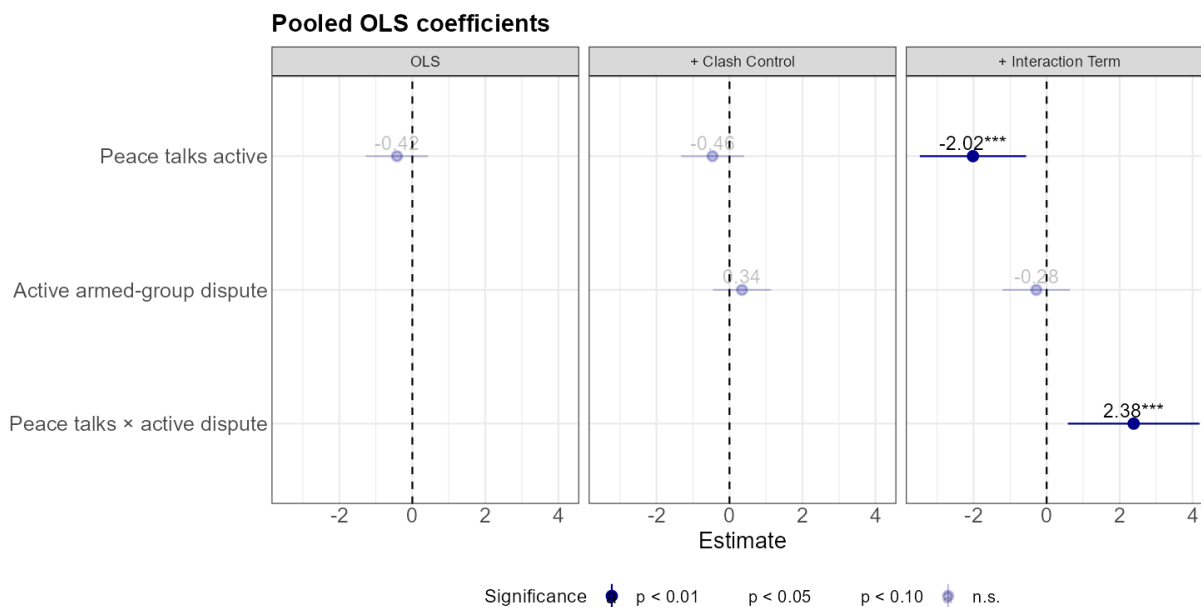


Figure 9: Pooled OLS coefficients across three specifications. Source: Author’s estimation.

This pooled pattern, however, conflates within-case effects with cross-case differences in baseline violence levels. The three cases enter the negotiation period at very different baselines, and the descriptive analysis showed that they follow divergent trajectories. The pooled OLS estimates therefore should not be interpreted as causal effects but as a descriptive starting point. The within-case story emerges only once the territorial fixed effects are introduced.

5.2 Case fixed effects

Once case fixed effects are added, the within-case variation in violence becomes the basis for inference. Figure 10 presents the case-FE coefficients. The treatment coefficient becomes negative and statistically significant at the five percent level when the clash control is added, and the clash coefficient is large, positive, and significant at the one percent level across specifications. When the interaction term is added the treatment coefficient becomes positive and loses statistical significance, while the negative interaction term suggests that the within-case association between peace talks and violence shifts in clash-active months.

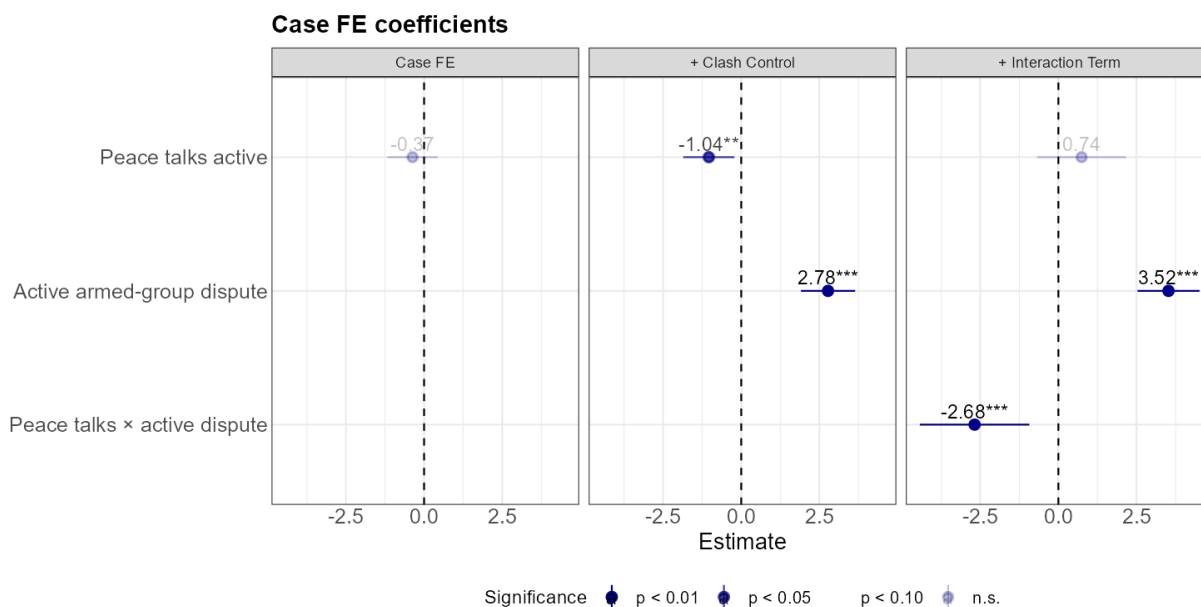


Figure 10: Case fixed-effects coefficients across three specifications. Source: Author's estimation.

This is the first specification in which the magnitudes of the coefficients begin to reflect the within-case logic of the design. The clash coefficient remains the largest and most stable in the model, suggesting that active armed-group dispute is a more powerful predictor of monthly violence than the negotiation period alone. The reversal of the treatment coefficient between the no-interaction and the interaction specifications reflects the conditional nature of the relationship that the descriptive analysis already anticipated.

5.3 Two-way fixed effects

The TWFE specification adds month fixed effects to absorb common shocks. Figure 11 presents the coefficients across three specifications: treatment alone, treatment with clash control, and the full interaction model. The treatment coefficient is positive across all three specifications, the clash coefficient is positive and large in the second and third specifications, and the interaction coefficient is negative.

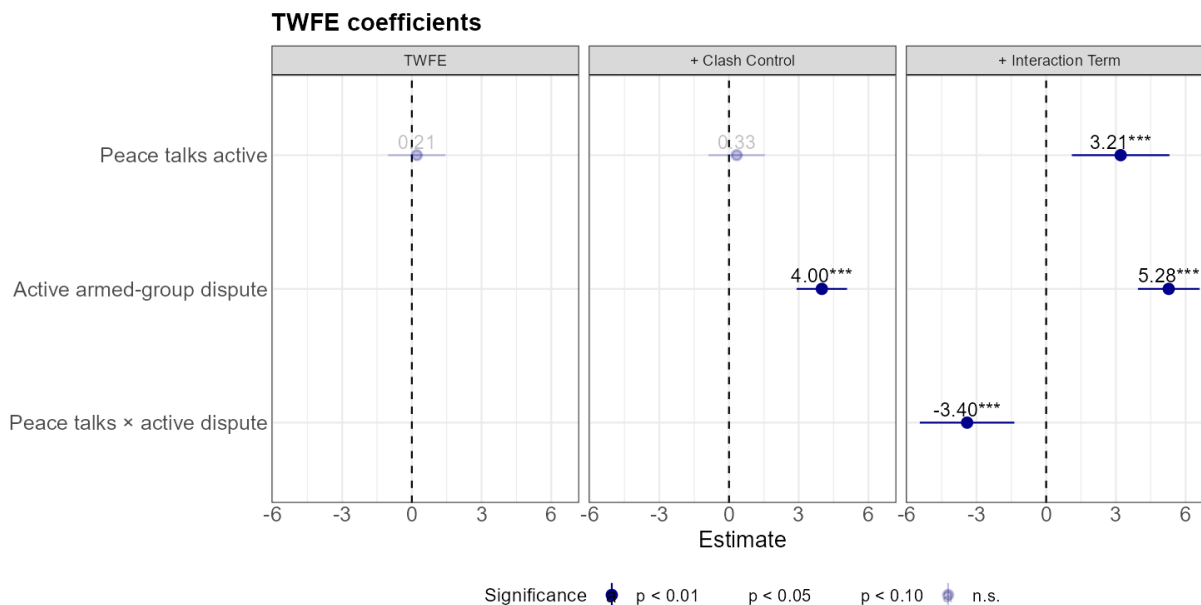


Figure 11: Two-way fixed-effects coefficients across three specifications. Source: Author's estimation.

The substantive interpretation is that the within-case association between peace talks and violence is positive in months without active clashes, and that this association attenuates when clashes are simultaneously active. The size of the clash coefficient relative to the treatment coefficient indicates that active armed-group dispute is the more powerful predictor of monthly violence in this design. The combined sign of the treatment coefficient and the interaction coefficient implies that, regardless of clash status, the treatment period is associated with an overall positive shift in monthly violence relative to the pre-treatment period within each case. This result supports the qualitative results and hypothesis, that PPT has in fact led to an increase in the levels of violence across territories.

Once case-level baselines are absorbed by the fixed effects, the within-case association between

peace talks and violence reverses sign, suggesting that the pooled estimates were biased by selection into treatment. Peace talks tend to occur in already-peaceful contexts, which biased the naive pooled estimate downward.

5.4 By-outcome models

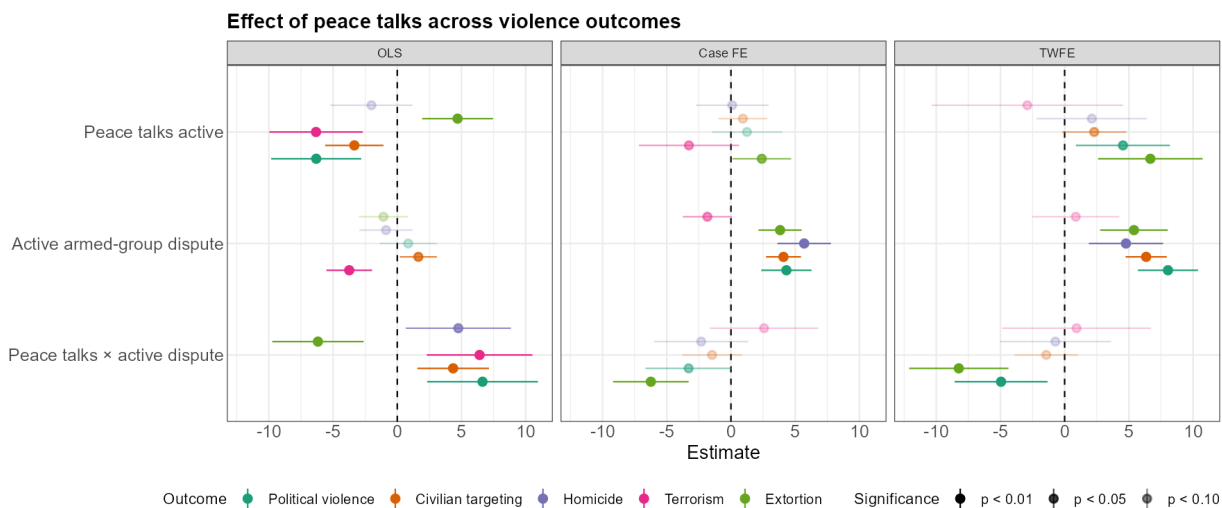


Figure 12: TWFE coefficients across violence outcomes and model specifications. Source: Author's estimation.

The disaggregated analysis tests whether the aggregate result is driven by specific violence types or whether it reflects a broader shift across the types of violence. Figure 12 presents the TWFE coefficients for each of the five outcomes (political violence, civilian targeting, homicide, terrorism, and extortion), with three model specifications presented within the figure.

The pattern most worth highlighting is for political violence, where the treatment coefficient is positive and statistically significant at the five percent level, and the interaction coefficient is negative and significant at the same level. This is consistent with a substantive interpretation in which negotiations attract political mobilization and counter-mobilization, particularly in months without active clashes, and where the presence of clashes redirects armed activity into other forms closer to subjective violence.

For civilian targeting, homicide, terrorism, and extortion, the treatment coefficients are imprecisely estimated and not statistically significant at conventional levels. This means that the aggregate increase associated with peace talks is concentrated in political violence rather than spread

evenly across all forms of violence. The clash coefficient remains positive and statistically significant for political violence, civilian targeting, and homicide, and becomes smaller and not significant for terrorism and extortion. The differentiation across outcomes is consistent with the theoretical framework: armed actors may reconfigure rather than abandon coercion during negotiations, and that the form of coercion depends on the local structure of armed governance.

H1 receives partial support from the disaggregated analysis: the timing of negotiations is associated with changes in the frequency of specific conflict-related events, but the association is not uniform across outcomes. Furthermore, the magnitude and direction are also pointing towards an increase in violent levels after the initiation of peace talks, with stronger effect at political violence specifically.

5.5 Robustness check: alternative count-data specifications

Since the outcome variable is a count of monthly violent events, ordinary least squares may underweight the skewed and non-negative distribution of the data. Cameron and Trivedi (2013) recommend that count outcomes be modeled with Poisson or negative binomial specifications, which respect the structural features of count data. The robustness check reports estimates from four specifications: the main TWFE OLS model, a DID model, a Poisson regression with case and month fixed effects, and a negative binomial regression with case and month fixed effects. The full table is reported in the appendix as table 2.

The negative binomial model is the most appropriate for these data on theoretical grounds. The dispersion parameter of 1.95 confirms substantial overdispersion, which violates the equidispersion assumption of the Poisson model, and the BIC strongly favors negative binomial over Poisson (7,945 versus 10,138).

Across all four specifications, the sign and significance of the key coefficients are preserved. Peace talks alone are associated with an increase in monthly violence, while the negative interaction with active armed-group disputes attenuates this effect. The point estimates are stable across specifications. The negative binomial treatment coefficient of 0.66, which exponentiated yields a rate ratio of 1.94, implies that peace talks are associated with roughly a doubling of the monthly violence rate in non-disputed contexts, with the interaction reducing this effect when armed-group disputes are simultaneously active.

The consistency of point estimates across the OLS, DID, Poisson, and negative binomial specifications strengthens confidence that the substantive findings are not artifacts of the distributional assumptions of OLS. The TWFE-OLS specification is retained for the main analysis given its standard place in difference-in-differences applications and the directness of its event-count interpretation. The count-data specifications are reported as robustness rather than as the main result.

The appendix also reports the same models with standard errors clustered at the case level. With only three territorial cases, cluster-robust inference must be interpreted cautiously, as the asymptotic theory underlying the procedure assumes a sampling framework, namely random selection of cases from a larger population, that does not match this study’s purposive case selection. Despite this caveat, the qualitative findings are preserved under clustered standard errors: the signs and significance of the main coefficients are largely unchanged. The interaction term loses some statistical precision in the OLS specification under clustering, but remains significant in both the Poisson and negative binomial models, which provides additional evidence that the conditional relationship between peace talks and violence is robust across inferential frameworks.

6 Discussion

Taken together, the regression results indicate that the implementation of Paz Total is associated with a general increase in observable violence across the three territorial cases. The TWFE specifications show that the within-case association between peace talks and aggregate monthly violence is positive, regardless of whether clashes are simultaneously active. The interaction term attenuates the effect during clash-active months, but the combined sign of the treatment and interaction coefficients indicates that the overall association remains positive across both clash conditions. The clash coefficient itself is the largest and most stable predictor in the model, which confirms that active armed-group dispute is the dominant driver of monthly violence, but it does not displace the independent positive association of the negotiation period with violence.

This pattern holds across the three count-data specifications reported in the robustness check. The negative binomial estimate of 0.66, which exponentiated yields a rate ratio of 1.94, implies that peace talks are associated with roughly a doubling of the monthly violence rate in non-disputed contexts, with the magnitude of the increase moderated but not eliminated when armed-group

disputes are simultaneously active. The consistency of this finding across OLS, Poisson, and negative binomial models, and across IID and clustered standard errors, strengthens confidence that the result is not an artifact of distributional assumptions or inferential framework.

The disaggregated by-outcome models show that this aggregate increase is most clearly visible in political violence, where the treatment coefficient is positive and statistically significant. For civilian targeting, homicide, terrorism, and extortion, the treatment coefficients are imprecisely estimated and not statistically significant at conventional levels. The aggregate association is therefore not driven uniformly by all forms of violence, but the absence of statistical significance in the disaggregated models does not contradict the aggregate finding. The combined repertoire of violence increases during the negotiation period, even when individual components do not show statistically significant changes on their own.

These results align with the theoretical framework, which argued that violence is a mechanism of armed governance rather than a simple expression of confrontation, and that negotiations may reconfigure the types of violence rather than uniformly reduce it. The findings suggest that the implementation of PPT opened a window in which the overall observable types of violence intensified across the three cases, with political violence emerging as the most identifiable component of that intensification. The remaining clash dynamics continue to drive a substantial part of monthly variation, but the negotiation period itself is associated with an additional positive shift that operates independently of clash activity.

This interpretation is consistent with qualitative and journalistic assessments that have characterized the policy as producing limited or counterproductive results during its implementation. The reports of FIP (FIP, 2026; Cajiao, 2026) and Ambos and Morales (2026) document a deterioration of security conditions during the policy’s implementation, with rising counts of disputes and combatants involved, and Johnson’s (2026) results also pointed towards a possible policy failure. The quantitative evidence presented here is consistent with that broader picture: peace talks, as implemented in these three cases, did not coincide with reductions in overall monthly violence and were instead associated with an increase across the types of violence. Hence, the policy seems to lead towards an increase in objective violence due to a shift in the local criminal governance status-quo, and dynamics that opened windows of opportunities for armed groups to consolidate their presence through coercion across the regions.

7 Conclusion

This thesis examined whether the implementation of Colombia’s *Política de Paz Total* was associated with a measurable change in the observable repertoire of objective violence across three territorial cases: Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco. The results indicated that the onset of peace talks was systematically linked to an increase in monthly violent events, with political violence emerging as the clearest disaggregated component of this rise, and active armed-group disputes operating as the dominant non-treatment driver.

These findings were consistent with the interpretation that the policy reconfigured the strategic incentives under which armed groups exerted territorial control in the territories (Johnson, 2026). In Arauca, where ELN governance most closely resembled Arjona’s (2016) rebelocracy, the negotiation period coincided with intensified competition from rival fronts. In Buenaventura, where Los Shottas and Los Espartanos operated as criminal-governance enclaves over specific neighborhoods, the clash-treatment interaction captured how internal ruptures shaped the within-period violence trajectory. In Tumaco, where multiple armed structures exerted regionalized control closer to what Arjona would call an *aliocratic* order, the increase in events reflected an open environment for the groups to consolidate position under reduced military pressure.

These results aligned with the qualitative literature that had already concluded the policy was producing limited or counterproductive outcomes (Johnson et al., 2025; FIP, 2026; Cajiao, 2026; Ambos and Morales, 2026), and were further consistent with the outgoing Petro administration’s own admission that the policy had failed to deliver on its central security promise (Swissinfo, 2026). Hence, the implications for the administration were direct: under the framework of objective violence used in this thesis, the policy did not reduce the population’s exposure to coercive practices across these regions, and in several specifications it appeared to have increased it.

Several limitations qualified the scope of these findings and must be addressed in further research. First, the policy was still in motion at the time of writing, and reports continued to emerge that this analysis could not incorporate; therefore, the most recent journalistic findings on individual negotiation tables would be relevant for any extension of the present analysis.

Second, the design measured only objective violence in Žižek’s (2010) sense, and the symbolic and subjective dimensions of coercion (forced disappearances, civilian intimidation, confinement,

child recruitment, and the everyday experience of armed governance) fell outside the empirical scope, even though the qualitative literature (Valencia and Serrano, 2025; Johnson et al., 2025) underscored their centrality to the lived security situation. This could be addressed in the future with Natural Language Processing tools or a mixed methods approach.

Third, the country-wide difference-in-differences robustness check showed that no Colombian department served as a credible counterfactual for the three cases, which limited inferential leverage beyond the within-case design. Future research should therefore extend the analysis in three directions: first, a country wide model with start dates documented at the same level of detail as the three cases studied here; second, the systematic coding of clash periods and resource flows for every department in negotiation, which would require sustained news-portal and field research; and third, the integration of qualitative measures of subjective violence with the quantitative panel, so that future evaluations of negotiated peace processes can speak to both the measurable repertoire and the lived experience of coercion under armed governance.

8 Appendix

Table 1: Robustness check: alternative count-data specifications

Dependent Variable:	count		
Model:	OLS (TWFE)	Poisson	Negative Binomial
	(1)	(2)	(3)
	OLS	Poisson	Neg. Bin.
<i>Variables</i>			
treatment_dummy	3.207** (0.7309)	0.6346*** (0.1739)	0.6642*** (0.1559)
clash_dummy	5.275** (0.9107)	0.8987*** (0.2299)	0.9643*** (0.2372)
treatment_dummy $\times$ clash_dummy	-3.403* (0.8531)	-0.7889*** (0.2666)	-0.8647*** (0.2525)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>			
case id	Yes	Yes	Yes
month id	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>			
Observations	1,263	1,263	1,263
Squared Correlation	0.29329	0.31581	0.29249
Pseudo R ²	0.05155	0.21399	0.06148
BIC	8,809.4	10,138.4	7,945.2
Over-dispersion			1.9514

Clustered (case id) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Standard errors in parentheses. All models include case and month fixed effects.

{Note:} The country-wide specifications include 25 treated units (the 3 study cases plus 22 departments touched by any Paz Total mesa) and omit the clash control and clash X treatment interaction because clash periods are coded only for the 3 study cases; extending the coding to the additional 22 departments lies beyond the scope of this thesis. **treatment** (Spec A) equals 1 only during active mesa months and switches off if a mesa is suspended, capturing the within-negotiation effect. **post** (Spec B) equals 1 from each unit's first mesa onward and remains 1 thereafter, capturing the persistent post-onset effect (even when talks later collapse).

Note: Columns (1) - (4) are country-wide specifications including 25 treated units (the 3 study cases plus 22 departments touched by any Paz Total mesa). The clash control and clash X treatment interaction are omitted from columns (1) - (4) because clash periods are coded only for the 3 study

Table 2: Robustness check: alternative count-data specifications

Dependent Variable:	count		
Model:	OLS (TWFE)	Poisson	Negative Binomial
	(1)	(2)	(3)
	OLS	Poisson	Neg. Bin.
<i>Variables</i>			
treatment_dummy	3.207*** (1.071)	0.6346*** (0.0839)	0.6642*** (0.1593)
clash_dummy	5.275*** (0.6753)	0.8987*** (0.0475)	0.9643*** (0.0985)
treatment_dummy $\times$ clash_dummy	-3.403*** (1.037)	-0.7889*** (0.0764)	-0.8647*** (0.1524)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>			
case id	Yes	Yes	Yes
month id	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>			
Observations	1,263	1,263	1,263
Squared Correlation	0.29329	0.31581	0.29249
Pseudo R ²	0.05155	0.21399	0.06148
BIC	8,809.4	10,138.4	7,945.2
Over-dispersion			1.9514

IID standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Standard errors in parentheses. All models include case and month fixed effects.

Table 3: Case fixed effects: effect of peace talks on aggregate monthly event counts

	Case FE	+ Clash Control	+ Interaction Term
Peace talks active	−0.37 (0.41)	−1.04** (0.42)	0.74 (0.72)
Active armed-group dispute		2.78*** (0.44)	3.52*** (0.51)
Peace talks × active dispute			−2.68*** (0.89)
Num. obs.	1263	1263	1263
Num. groups: case id	3	3	3
R ² (full model)	0.16	0.19	0.19
R ² (proj model)	0.00	0.03	0.04
Adj. R ² (full model)	0.16	0.19	0.19
Adj. R ² (proj model)	−0.00	0.03	0.04

Standard errors in parentheses.

All columns include territorial-case fixed effects.

Col. (3): Adds peace talks × active armed-group dispute.

Table 4: Pooled OLS: effect of peace talks on aggregate monthly event counts

	OLS	+ Clash Control	+ Interaction Term
Constant	7.36*** (0.23)	7.16*** (0.33)	7.51*** (0.35)
Peace talks active	−0.42 (0.44)	−0.46 (0.44)	−2.02*** (0.74)
Active armed-group dispute		0.34 (0.41)	−0.28 (0.47)
Peace talks × active dispute			2.38*** (0.92)
R ²	0.00	0.00	0.01
Adj. R ²	−0.00	−0.00	0.00
Num. obs.	1263	1263	1263

Standard errors in parentheses.

Col. (3): Peace talks, active armed-group dispute, and treat.×dispute.

Table 5: Two-way fixed effects: effect of peace talks on aggregate monthly event counts

	TWFE	+ Clash Control	+ Interaction Term
Peace talks active	0.21 (0.63)	0.33 (0.62)	3.21*** (1.07)
Active armed-group dispute		4.00*** (0.55)	5.28*** (0.68)
Peace talks $\times$ active dispute			-3.40*** (1.04)
Num. obs.	1263	1263	1263
Num. groups: case id	3	3	3
Num. groups: month id	99	99	99
R ² (full model)	0.25	0.29	0.29
R ² (proj model)	0.00	0.04	0.05
Adj. R ² (full model)	0.19	0.22	0.23
Adj. R ² (proj model)	-0.00	0.04	0.05

Standard errors in parentheses.

All columns include territorial-case and month fixed effects.

Col. (3): Adds peace talks $\times$ active armed-group dispute.

Table 6: Case fixed-effects models by violence outcome (with clash control and interaction)

	Political violence	Civilian targeting	Homicide	Terrorism	Extortion
Peace talks active	1.25 (1.39)	0.92 (0.97)	0.10 (1.44)	-3.27* (1.97)	2.40** (1.16)
Active armed-group dispute	4.32*** (0.99)	4.09*** (0.69)	5.70*** (1.06)	-1.84* (0.97)	3.83*** (0.85)
Peace talks $\times$ active dispute	-3.30* (1.70)	-1.47 (1.19)	-2.32 (1.86)	2.58 (2.13)	-6.24*** (1.49)
Num. obs.	297	297	274	147	248
Num. groups: case id	3	3	3	3	3
R ² (full model)	0.51	0.45	0.35	0.27	0.46
R ² (proj model)	0.06	0.12	0.11	0.06	0.10
Adj. R ² (full model)	0.50	0.44	0.33	0.25	0.45
Adj. R ² (proj model)	0.05	0.11	0.10	0.04	0.09

Standard errors in parentheses.

Each column is a separate violence outcome (monthly event counts).

Table 7: OLS models by violence outcome (with clash control and interaction)

	Political violence	Civilian targeting	Homicide	Terrorism	Extortion
Peace talks active	−6.31*** (1.78)	−3.34*** (1.15)	−2.01 (1.63)	−6.33*** (1.84)	4.70*** (1.40)
Active armed-group dispute	0.85 (1.13)	1.64** (0.73)	−0.88 (1.05)	−3.74*** (0.90)	−1.08 (0.96)
Peace talks × active dispute	6.64*** (2.19)	4.35*** (1.42)	4.75** (2.08)	6.41*** (2.08)	−6.18*** (1.81)
R ²	0.06	0.09	0.02	0.16	0.09
Adj. R ²	0.05	0.08	0.01	0.14	0.08
Num. obs.	297	297	274	147	248

Standard errors in parentheses.

Each column is a separate violence outcome (monthly event counts).

Table 8: TWFE models by violence outcome (with clash control and interaction)

	Political violence	Civilian targeting	Homicide	Terrorism	Extortion
Peace talks active	4.54** (1.86)	2.30* (1.27)	2.12 (2.18)	−2.91 (3.70)	6.67*** (2.06)
Active armed-group dispute	8.05*** (1.19)	6.35*** (0.81)	4.78*** (1.47)	0.86 (1.68)	5.40*** (1.33)
Peace talks × active dispute	−4.95*** (1.84)	−1.43 (1.26)	−0.72 (2.20)	0.93 (2.88)	−8.24*** (1.96)
Num. obs.	297	297	274	98	248
Num. groups: case id	3	3	3	3	3
Num. groups: month id	99	99	99	46	99
R ² (full model)	0.73	0.71	0.60	0.71	0.67
R ² (proj model)	0.20	0.28	0.09	0.04	0.13
Adj. R ² (full model)	0.58	0.55	0.35	0.40	0.43
Adj. R ² (proj model)	0.18	0.27	0.07	−0.02	0.11

Standard errors in parentheses.

Each column is a separate violence outcome (monthly event counts).

Table 9: Country-wide DiD robustness: Spec A (active window) vs. Spec B (absorbing post), baseline (Step 1) vs. narrow controls (Step 2).

Dependent Variable:	count			
Model:	Step1 Spec A (1)	Step1 Spec B (2)	Step2 Spec A (3)	Step2 Spec B (4)
<i>Variables</i>				
treatment	2.841 (5.056)		1.338 (3.814)	
post		6.430 (6.138)		5.916 (4.825)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
unit_id	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
month_id	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>				
Observations	3,644	3,644	2,871	2,871
R ²	0.90235	0.90274	0.90509	0.90543
Within R ²	0.00114	0.00514	0.00027	0.00385

Clustered (unit_id) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Standard errors clustered at the unit (department or case-cluster) level.

Table 10: DiD robustness: full panel, narrow panel, and cases + clash.

Dependent Variable:	count				
Model:	Full/Active	Full/Perm	Narrow/Active	Narrow/Perm	Cases+ctrls+clash
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
<i>Variables</i>					
treatment	1.564 (5.306)		1.338 (3.814)		1.806 (3.630)
post		4.872 (6.757)		5.916 (4.825)	
clash					16.11** (6.179)
treatment $\times$ clash					-10.11 (8.270)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>					
unit_id	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
month_id	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>					
Observations	3,465	3,465	2,871	2,871	693
R ²	0.90097	0.90121	0.90509	0.90543	0.70759
Within R ²	0.00034	0.00278	0.00027	0.00385	0.10310

Clustered (unit_id) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Standard errors clustered at the unit level.

cases. Column (5) restores the clash control and interaction by restricting the panel to the 3 study cases plus the 4 narrow controls (Cundinamarca, Boyacá, Caldas, Quindío), where **clash** is well defined (set to 0 for the controls by construction). **treatment** equals 1 only during active mesa months and switches off if a mesa is suspended (within-negotiation effect); **post** equals 1 from each unit's first mesa onward and remains 1 thereafter (persistent post-onset effect).

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